

The Masterclass Series

Six advanced modules for the specialist worlds a private concierge must move through with ease.

The eight-week programme makes you fluent in the craft. These masterclasses make you fluent in its specialist domains, the ones where a single wrong word marks you as an outsider and a single right one marks you as a professional. Read the one you need before you need it.

Masterclass I · The Yacht

Who is who. The **captain** holds absolute authority aboard, in law, over the vessel and everyone on it, including the principal's requests. You never instruct a captain; you ask what is possible. The **chief stewardess** runs the interior and the guest experience, and is your true counterpart on the water. The **charter broker** represents the principal; the **central agent** represents the yacht. A **yacht manager** runs the vessel's operations year-round, and on larger yachts a **purser** manages the accounts and the APA.

The vocabulary that matters. The **charter fee** is the base price to hire the yacht. On top sit the **APA** (Advance Provisioning Allowance, usually 25 to 35 per cent of the fee, held by the captain for fuel, food, dockage and extras), **VAT** depending on cruising waters, and a **crew gratuity** of roughly 5 to 15 per cent. The contract is the **MYBA agreement**. **Delivery** and **redelivery** define where the charter legally begins and ends.

The number nobody quotes. A yacht advertised at 200,000 a week is never 200,000. Add APA, VAT and gratuity and the real, all-in figure is closer to 290,000. Always quote your principal the all-in cost, never the sticker price.

How you operate. You build the relationship with the chief stewardess first; the whole trip runs through it. And the sentence that shows you know this world: *"Captain, the principal would like to be in Portofino for dinner on Thursday. What is possible?"*

Masterclass II · Private Aviation

The three ways to fly private. **Ownership** (the family owns the aircraft, with a flight department or a management company). **Fractional ownership** (a share in an aircraft, bought as a set number of hours per year). **Charter** (hire by the trip). Each has different economics, and knowing which your principal uses tells you who to call.

The vocabulary. The **FBO** is the private terminal you arrive at, not the main airport; there is no queue and often no walk. The **tail number** identifies the aircraft. An **empty leg** is a repositioning

flight with no passengers, offered at a fraction of the price. **Ground handling** covers everything on the tarmac. Catering, luggage limits and crew are all arranged ahead through the operator.

How you operate. You confirm the aircraft, the FBO, the crew contact and the catering days ahead. You pack to the aircraft's limits, not the family's optimism. You anticipate jet lag by quietly adjusting the first day's meals and plans. And you never let a principal discover a delay from anyone but you, with the alternative already in hand.

The register to know. Learn the difference between charter, fractional and empty leg, and you can offer real value on a principal's travel without ever compromising on privacy or standard.

Masterclass III · Fine Dining & Wine

Service. Silver service transfers food from platter to plate with a spoon and fork in one hand; where it is expected, competence is assumed and clumsiness is instantly seen. Know the **brigade** of a kitchen (chef de cuisine, sous-chef, chefs de partie) so you address the right person for the right thing. The **maitre d'hotel** runs the dining room, and a relationship with a great one opens tables no booking system can.

Wine. A **cru** is a vineyard of recognised quality; **grand cru** and **premier cru** are the highest classifications in regions like Burgundy and Bordeaux. **Decanting** separates an older red from its sediment and lets it breathe; offer it for a mature red without being asked. **En primeur** is buying wine as a future, still in the barrel. Trust the **sommelier** and ask their guidance rather than performing knowledge; it yields the finer pairing.

The map to carry. Know the strong and weak vintages of the major regions, recognise a grand cru on a list, and understand that serious Champagne is now often served in a white-wine glass, not a flute, to release its aroma. Know what a **Michelin star** truly means: one is a real achievement, three is exceptionally rare.

The one rule. Guide a hesitant principal gently toward the chef's judgement, the tasting menu, the sommelier's pairing. The confidence to defer is itself a mark of taste.

Masterclass IV · Art & Collections

The word that governs everything. Provenance: the documented history of ownership of a work. Strong provenance authenticates, protects value and reassures; a gap in it raises questions. Always ask for it before advising a purchase, and never let a valuable move without a record (see the Inventory in your toolkit).

How the world works. An **art advisor** guides acquisitions and sales discreetly. Auction houses run on **lots**, **reserves** (the minimum the seller will accept) and a **buyer's premium** on top of the hammer price. A **freepoint** is a secure, tax-advantaged storage facility where serious collections

often live. **Conservation** and handling are specialist trades; fine art is moved by dedicated shippers, never by the household.

How you operate. You coordinate, you never handle. You keep the register current, you manage the specialists (shippers, conservators, insurers, hangers), and you protect the collection's paperwork as carefully as the works themselves. When something is lent, insured, restored or sold, the record is updated the same day.

The mark of the insider. Old money treasures **patina**, the evidence of age and quality; to over-restore an heirloom is to erase its story. Knowing this, and saying it at the right moment, signals real fluency.

Masterclass V · Security & Close Protection

Who they are. The **close-protection team**, or **the detail**, is the trained team around the principal and the family. You coordinate with them; you do not manage them, and you never plan a movement without them. The best relationship with a detail is quiet, respectful and constant.

The vocabulary. An **advance** is the reconnaissance of a location before the principal arrives. A **threat assessment** shapes how a trip is run. Comms, routes, timings, guest lists and schedules are shared with the team, always. Residential security covers the home; the detail covers the person.

How you operate. You share the itinerary early and completely. You treat every route, guest and movement as sensitive information. You know the procedure for an unknown person at the gate and for a journalist's approach: decline, and flag it. A beautiful itinerary that ignores security is not a service, it is a risk.

The reflex. Before you confirm any plan, ask yourself who on the detail needs to know, and tell them first. Anticipation, here, can matter more than anywhere else in the house.

Masterclass VI · The Family Office

What it is. The private structure that manages a wealthy family's wealth, investments, legal affairs, philanthropy and often its household staff. A **single-family office** serves one family; a **multi-family office** serves several. In many houses it is the family office, not the family, that actually hires you, pays you, and holds your reference.

Who is who. Know who **signs**, who **decides**, and who merely **relays**. The **chief of staff** or **principal's private office** sits at the top of the operation; the **estate manager** runs the residences; the family office runs the money and the structure. Confusing these lines is a classic and costly error.

How you operate. You learn the reporting lines in your first week and you respect them absolutely. Budgets, expenses and household reporting flow to the family office cleanly and on time (see the

Budget in your toolkit). You treat the office with the same discretion you give the family, because they are the same confidence.

The professional's summit. The most senior role in this world, chief of staff to a private household, is reached through years of proven trust, never through a certificate. Understanding the family office is the first step in seeing the whole board, and one day, perhaps, running it.

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